

JACKPOT JOES

BRETT LEE
(MOHALI)
(\$900,000)
Rs 3.6 crore



JACQUES KALLIS
(BANGALORE)
(\$900,000)
Rs 3.6 crore



CHRIS GAYLE
(KOLKATA)
(\$800,000)
Rs 3.2 crore



YOUSUF PATHAN
(JAIPUR)
(\$475,000)
Rs 1.9 crore



JOGINDER SHARMA
(CHENNAI)
(\$225,000)
Rs 90 lakh



AJIT AGARKAR
(KOLKATA)
(\$330,000)
Rs 1.32 crore



photographers didn't desist and Modi shouted, "I'm *really* upset now." It is what the rest of the world could well have been shouting at him because IPL has caused widespread alarm amongst boards. Players though have sighted years of earnings being available in weeks and leapt at the idea.

Australia have now asked ICC to identify a window for the event that would not clash with their bilateral tours in the future. There is a move to have the next IPL brought forward by two weeks to give England's players a shot at the pot of gold. No Englishman will be involved in IPL this year as the tournament clashes with the start of their county season. IPL Governing Council member I.S. Bindra says,

"Some adjustments will have to be made to fit the England players in." The next step will be to find a place in the calendar for the Champions T20, which will feature the winners of IPL against the domestic T20 champions from Australia, England and South Africa.

On the day of the auction, commentators at a domestic 50-overs game being played at an empty Sydney

A low-profile Jacob Oram was auctioned for a higher price than Matthew Hayden and Ricky Ponting.

Cricket Ground digested the figures from IPL bids. A double take and a small silence were needed to swallow the fact that a low-profile Kiwi like Jacob Oram had pulled in \$675,000 to Matthew Hayden's \$357,000 and captain Ricky Ponting's very modest \$400,000. "You would have thought it was closer than that," murmured the first commentator to find his voice.

The issue of availability may have led to this price cut; team owners knew the Aussies wouldn't be available for this year's edition as they were to tour Pakistan. As the auctioneer's hammer went down on the first batch of cricketers, came the news that Andrew Symonds, who was bought by Hyderabad for \$1.35 million, said he was contemplating dropping out from Pakistan. Over security fears.

IPL franchises are now left holding their big brood of babies. They have their teams, their teams have an event that begins in less than two months. Already some are feeling frazzled. A Delhi insider said all team owners wanted was to get the first tournament under way and over with. "We'll see what to do about the brand and building later." Another exhausted bidder looked back at the race to make the auction deadline saying, "It's a wonder how things get done. It's amateur, seat of the pants stuff."

For it to become the competition that actually changes cricket's economy and world order, the IPL will have to become something other than a mere cash counter. It will have to do as much as team owners to deliver an event that fans enjoy and support.

Amateur hour is over. ■



STRATEGY: Kolkata team owner Shah Rukh Khan with icon Ganguly